

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



A train approaches the bump at the Belt Railway Co. Clearing Yard on Dec. 11, 2023. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Rail merger critics warn of power consolidation

They say Union Pacific would get an unprecedented role in Chicago and more control of the rail industry, but the firm’s executive says the competitive threat is exaggerated

By John Lippert
Chicago Tribune

If regulators approve its merger with Norfolk Southern, competitors warn that Union Pacific could turn the city of Chicago into a hammer for seizing even more control of the industry.

Their concern centers on two tiny Chicago railroads that have hauled freight across town for all comers since the 1890s.

The Belt Railway Co. of Chicago and the Indiana Harbor Railroad are owned separately by groups of big railroads. Their tracks run in parallel arcs roughly from O’Hare International Airport in the north to Gary in the south.

They also operate switching yards that take herds of boxcars, tank cars and auto haulers, brought continually into Chicago by the big railroads, and sort them into specific trains bound for, say, New York or Baltimore.

The merger would boost Union Pacific’s stake in the Belt Railway of Chicago to 33.3% from 8.3% today, and in the Indiana Harbor Belt to 25.2% from zero currently, according to its application to federal regulators.

That would give Jim Vena, chief executive of Omaha, Nebraska-based Union Pacific, more control of the city’s rail traffic than anyone else in Chicago history, said Earl Wacker, a former CSX executive.

“I don’t know how he leverages this, but he’s going to leverage it,” said Wacker, who now works with RINA North America, a global engineering firm with offices in Chicago. “He’s not buying it not to leverage it.”

Vena’s 33.3% stake in the Belt Railway of Chicago, for example, falls just short of what he would need to veto a big capital spending plan even if all the other voters want it.

In an interview, Vena accused other railroads of greatly exaggerating the competitive threat.

“If you own 30% of something, and you have 30% of the voice, you still have 70% that you have to deal with,” he said.

“We have (8.3%) of the Belt (Railway) and listen, our voices

are heard. We’re all equal in there. We hire the best person to operate the Belt railroad to be efficient and to be able to move products for all of us.”

In any case, Vena said, the combined railroad will put less strain on the Belt Railway of Chicago and the Indiana Harbor Belt by running more cross-country trains that either bypass Chicago or pass straight through the city without stopping to exchange freight.

In its merger application, Union Pacific said the combined railroad would send 200 fewer cars to the Belt Railway of Chicago each day. That’s about a tenth of the Belt’s current total.

Turn to Merger, Page 2

Trial will put feds’ rhetoric to test

Chicago man is accused of plotting gang hit on Bovino, but evidence of gang ties has weakened

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Operation Midway Blitz was in high gear in early October when authorities made a sensational announcement: An alleged ranking member of Chicago’s Latin Kings street gang had been arrested in a murder-for-hire plot targeting Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino.

The news quickly thrust Juan Espinoza Martinez, a 37-year-old Mexican-born carpenter, into the national spectacle of the Trump administration’s aggressive deportation push, with the U.S. attorney’s office calling him “a ruthless and violent” gang member and senior officials holding the case up as an example of the threats immigration officials were facing from international drug cartels.

But as Espinoza Martinez heads to trial Tuesday, the rhetoric is about to meet the road.

In the months since Espinoza Martinez was charged, evidence of his supposed gang affiliations has not materialized. Prosecutors vastly toned down that aspect of the case, first dropping mention of gang affiliation in the indictment handed up by a grand jury, then saying in a pretrial hearing they only intended to prove Espinoza Martinez had an “affinity” for the Latin Kings.

Then, last week, the federal judge overseeing the case barred prosecutors from presenting any mention of his ties to the Latin Kings to avoid prejudicing the jury. Instead, prosecutors will be allowed to ask a key cooperator about what he thought Espinoza Martinez meant in certain text messages where he made references to “LK,” and play for the jury excerpts of Espinoza’s post-arrest interview, where he acknowledged telling the informant, “Latin Kings

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INSIDE



Morgan Park High School majorettes perform in Chicago. **STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE**

On MLK Jr. Day, protests, politics and pride

■ Chicago Mayor Brandon Johnson taps into anger against President Donald Trump at annual breakfast; hundreds of protesters demonstrate against ICE in Chicago; and volunteers unite to beautify Morgan Park High School, **Chicagoland Page 3**

■ MLK’s message serves as rallying cry across nation. **Nation & World**

Trump ties Greenland stance to Nobel loss

President Donald Trump linked his aggressive position to last year’s decision not to award him the Nobel Peace Prize, in a message to Norway’s prime minister. **Nation and World**

They voted for Trump. Now they have concerns

At one-year milestone, immigration actions a repeated complaint for the dissatisfied

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
Chicago Tribune

Frustrated with the way the country was headed, Pablo Payan cast a ballot for Donald Trump in 2024, mainly drawn to the Republican presidential candidate’s pledge to bring economic strength to the nation as well as an America First mindset.

The father of four from Merrillville usually favored Democrats in the past but was hoping for a nationwide change of direction. Less foreign aid. More border security. Lower inflation. Greater economic growth.

Yet roughly a year into Trump’s second presidency, Payan has buyer’s remorse.

“I did vote for Trump. But now I regret it,” Payan said. “He’s contradicting everything he said he would do. And now it’s extremism. And immigration. And racial profiling. And sending money to foreign countries.”

As the one-year milestone of the second Trump administration approaches, various polls indicate waning approval for the president compared with the higher ratings he had at the start of his second term.



Contractor Pablo Payan, of Merrillville, Indiana, regrets his vote for Trump. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

A Reuters/Ipsos poll earlier this month showed 42% of Americans approved of Trump’s job overall. This was up slightly from lower percentages throughout most of the fall and winter but still down from the 47% approval rating around the time Trump took office in January 2025.

While the president has kept

his MAGA base largely intact, the Tribune interviewed several Trump voters who have expressed dissatisfaction with aspects of his leadership during the first year of his second term.

Although they favored the president over Democrat Kamala Harris during the campaign, they now share grave concerns over the

Trump administration’s handling of everything from economic strategies to foreign policy to domestic problems.

Aggressive immigration enforcement was a repeated complaint from those who backed the president during the election

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